

On being unequally yoked

2 Corinthians 6:14-18

- ¹⁴ Be ye not unequally yoked together with unbelievers: for what fellowship hath righteousness with unrighteousness? and what communion hath light with darkness?
- ¹⁵ And what concord hath Christ with Belial? or what part hath he that believeth with an infidel?
- ¹⁶ And what agreement hath the temple of God with idols? for ye are the temple of the living God; as God hath said, I will dwell in them, and walk in them; and I will be their God, and they shall be my people.
- ¹⁷ Wherefore come out from among them, and be ye separate, saith the Lord, and touch not the unclean thing; and I will receive you,
- ¹⁸ And will be a Father unto you, and ye shall be my sons and daughters, saith the Lord Almighty.

Imagine we have a married couple and one of them gets born again after they were married. Some may think that this verse is commanding that the born again partner must divorce the unbelieving partner: but if you think carefully that would create a contradiction in the word of God. And because of that we can easily know that we aren't rightly dividing the word of truth.

Let's take that same situation and look at 1Cor 7:

1 Corinthians 7:10-16

- ¹⁰ And unto the married I command, yet not I, but the Lord, Let not the wife depart from her husband:
- ¹¹ But and if she depart, let her remain unmarried, or be reconciled to her husband: and let not the husband put away his wife.
- ¹² But to the rest speak I, not the Lord: If any brother hath a wife that believeth not, and she be pleased to dwell with him, let him not put her away.
- ¹³ And the woman which hath an husband that believeth not, and if he be pleased to dwell with her, let her not leave him.
- ¹⁴ For the unbelieving husband is sanctified by the wife, and the unbelieving wife is sanctified by the husband: else were your children unclean; but now are they holy.
- ¹⁵ But if the unbelieving depart, let him depart. A brother or a sister is not under bondage in such cases: but God hath called us to peace.
- ¹⁶ For what knowest thou, O wife, whether thou shalt save thy husband? or how knowest thou, O man, whether thou shalt save thy wife?

Here we are told that if one partner of the married couple is a believer and the other is not “*let him **not** put her away*” and “*let her **not** leave him*”. If 2Cor 6:14 were about married couples then the Bible would be giving conflicting advice. Since that's not even possible, let's back up for a moment (Proverbs 4:27b).

1Cor 7 is obviously about married couples and 2Cor 6 doesn't mention marriage at all. So, if 2Cor 6:14 is not about married couples that begs the question: what is it about?

For that, we'll look at the entire context of the verse and also look more closely at the verse itself.

2 Corinthians 6:1-18

1 We then, as workers together with him, beseech you also that ye receive not the grace of God in vain.
2 (For he saith, I have heard thee in a time accepted, and in the day of salvation have I succoured thee: behold, now is the accepted time; behold, now is the day of salvation.)
3 Giving no offence in any thing, that the ministry be not blamed:
4 But in all things approving ourselves as the ministers of God, in much patience, in afflictions, in necessities, in distresses,
5 In stripes, in imprisonments, in tumults, in labours, in watchings, in fastings;
6 By pureness, by knowledge, by longsuffering, by kindness, by the Holy Ghost, by love unfeigned,
7 By the word of truth, by the power of God, by the armour of righteousness on the right hand and on the left,
8 By honour and dishonour, by evil report and good report: as deceivers, and yet true;
9 As unknown, and yet well known; as dying, and, behold, we live; as chastened, and not killed;
10 As sorrowful, yet always rejoicing; as poor, yet making many rich; as having nothing, and yet possessing all things.
11 O ye Corinthians, our mouth is open unto you, our heart is enlarged.
12 Ye are not straitened in us, but ye are straitened in your own bowels.
13 Now for a recompence in the same, (I speak as unto my children,) be ye also enlarged.
14 Be ye not unequally yoked together with unbelievers: for what fellowship hath righteousness with unrighteousness? and what communion hath light with darkness?
15 And what concord hath Christ with Belial? or what part hath he that believeth with an infidel?
16 And what agreement hath the temple of God with idols? for ye are the temple of the living God; as God hath said, I will dwell in them, and walk in them; and I will be their God, and they shall be my people.
17 Wherefore come out from among them, and be ye separate, saith the Lord, and touch not the unclean thing; and I will receive you,
18 And will be a Father unto you, and ye shall be my sons and daughters, saith the Lord Almighty.

The first verse of 2Cor 6 gives us the context for the entire chapter: working together. It starts out talking about us working together with God and ends with warnings against working together with the wicked (Proverbs 3:33). Because it has nothing to do with marriage there is no contradiction with the rest of scripture.

Take the picture of a yoke and what is it? It's typically a wooden device that links two (or more) oxen together to do what? To work together! In it's context both the word and verse itself fit perfectly. It's only when we take any verse out of it's context that we venture towards error.

The phrase "Be ye not unequally yoked together with unbelievers" is followed by a colon, which is followed by 5 parallelisms to give us more understanding about exactly what is being said:

Righteousness	Fellowship	Unrighteousness
Light	Communion	Darkness
Christ	Concord	Belial
He that believeth	Part	Infidel
Temple of the living God	Agreement	Idols

Imagine two oxen yoked together but pulling in opposite directions. It doesn't really make a lot of sense does it?

Now let's take those parallelisms from 2Cor 6 and have a look at a real example that we are given in the old testament of "Be ye not unequally yoked with unbelievers" and the consequences of doing so:

2 Chronicles 20:35-37 35 And after this did Jehoshaphat king of Judah join himself with Ahaziah king of Israel, who did very wickedly: 36 And he joined himself with him to make ships to go to Tarshish: and they made the ships in Ezion-geber. 37 Then Eliezer the son of Dodavah of Mareshah prophesied against Jehoshaphat, saying, Because thou hast joined thyself with Ahaziah, the LORD hath broken thy works. And the ships were broken, that they were not able to go to Tarshish.

Take notice also that each column uses different names for the same/similar things. These are called parallelisms: where the "same thing" is called by different names or phrases.

They can teach us different aspects/qualities of a thing and they can also give us new definitions or words to describe the same thing or action.

There are many of them in the Bible, and they are very handy for letting the word of God define itself: which is crucial for rightly dividing the word of truth. Parallelisms are relatively easy to see once you know to look for them. Some of them are obvious and some of them require us to stop and think carefully.

Genesis 1:2 And the earth was without form, and void; and darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters.	Two different words for the same thing.
Judges 18:17-20 17 And the five men that went to spy out the land went up, and came in thither, and took the graven image, and the ephod, and the teraphim, and the molten image: and the priest stood in the entering of the gate with the six hundred men that were appointed with weapons of war. 18 And these went into Micah's house, and fetched the carved image, the ephod, and the teraphim, and the molten image. Then said the priest unto them, What do ye?	Two complete lists and one of the things is given two different adjectives.
Job 38:5 Who hath laid the measures thereof, if thou knowest? or who hath stretched the line upon it?	Two phrases that describe the same action.
Job 38:17 Have the gates of death been opened unto thee? or hast thou seen the doors of the shadow of death?	Two different words representing the same idea.
1 Samuel 20:24-27 24 So David hid himself in the field: and when the new moon was come, the king sat him down to eat meat. 25 And the king sat upon his seat, as at other times, even upon a seat by the wall: and Jonathan arose, and Abner sat by Saul's side, and David's place was empty. 26 Nevertheless Saul spake not any thing that day: for he thought, Something hath befallen him, he is not clean; surely he is not clean. 27 And it came to pass on the morrow, which was the second day of the month, that David's place was empty: and Saul said unto Jonathan his son, Wherefore cometh not the son of Jesse to meat, neither yesterday, nor to day?	"the new moon" is the same as "the first day of the month"